

I Hedonism

I.1 Introduction

The simplest theory of well-being is hedonism. This is the view that all and only pleasure is good for you and that all and only pain is bad for you.

To avoid confusion, it is important to be clear that the hedonist makes these claims solely about what is *non-instrumentally* good for you and bad for you. They allow that things other than pleasure can be good for us *instrumentally*, things such as money, friendship, a nice house, and painkillers. But the hedonist will say that these things are good for us in a non-fundamental, or derivative, way because they are simply means to pleasure or the avoidance of pain.

It is easy to see the appeal of hedonism. When we think about lives that seem to have gone well for the person who lives them, it is difficult to imagine them either lacking pleasure or being full of painful episodes. The paradigm cases of people whose lives are going well for them all experience great joy and pleasure in a wide range of things and experience little serious pain. Furthermore, when explaining why something would be good for someone, the claim that it would be pleasurable seems obviously to be good evidence of its goodness for them. Conversely, 'it is painful for them' provides a very plausible account of why something is bad for someone. Thus, the pre-theoretical appeal of hedonism is clear. (In this book I will use 'hedonism' to refer only to hedonism about well-being, rather than the many other forms of hedonism.)

It will be useful now to think a bit more precisely about hedonism and about the arguments for it. Here, first, is a more precise formulation of hedonism about well-being:

Hedonism: All and only pleasure is (non-instrumentally) good for us. All and only pain is (non-instrumentally) bad for us. A person's overall well-being is determined solely by the balance of pleasure and pain they experience.

(Henceforth I often omit the 'non-instrumentally' for the sake of readability. All claims about what is *good* for us should be taken to be about what is *non-instrumentally good* for us, unless otherwise specified.)

Questions left open

This formulation of hedonism is sufficiently precise for our purposes but it leaves open some questions. First, it says nothing about what pleasure or pain *are*.¹ Second, it does not tell us how to get precise answers about a person's well-being. For example, it does not say exactly *how* the degree of prudential value of a pleasure is determined. It does not tell us how the *intensity* of a pleasure and its *duration* serve to determine its prudential value (and vice versa for pain). Although hedonists have assumed, reasonably, that increases in either duration or intensity make pleasures more prudentially valuable (and pains more prudentially disvaluable) hedonists have not much considered exactly how these factors interact. More than one view is possible here (one might give priority to intensity, or to duration, or endorse some complex function of both).

Hedonic levels

It will be useful to talk about a person's *hedonic level*. By this I mean their *overall* balance of pleasure and pain. To get the idea, imagine that you are celebrating a recent success (a new job, finishing your degree, etc.), enjoying exquisite food and drink in the company of those you love. However, at the same time you have the painful soreness from a recently injured knee and your chair is rather uncomfortable. Thus, whilst you experience pleasure from some aspects of your situation (the success, the food and drink, the company) you experience pain from others (your knee, the uncomfortable chair). The balance of the pleasure and pain that you experience is your *hedonic level* at that time.

If hedonism is true then it would follow that a person's hedonic level is *correlated with* their well-being. Any increase, or decrease, in the one would *necessarily* mean an increase, or decrease, in the other. To put this less abstractly, if hedonism is true then the following must be true. First, if someone's hedonic level increases (they experience more pleasure and/or less pain) then their level of well-being increases. Second, if someone's hedonic level decreases then their level of well-being decreases. Third, if someone's well-being increases then their hedonic level increases (they experience more pleasure and/or less pain). Finally, if someone's well-being decreases then their hedonic level decreases.

1.2 Arguments for hedonism

Paradigm cases and correlation arguments

One kind of evidence that a hedonist can appeal to in support of the view is the correlation between a person's well-being and their hedonic level. For example:

Raj on the Rollercoaster: Raj is enjoying a rollercoaster ride. Suddenly, a bird flies into his face, which is very painful. After getting off the ride Raj is given some

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painkillers which numb the area and he feels no pain. His friend then buys him candy floss, which he loves, and pleurably eats.

The hedonist might ask us to observe that in this case it seems plausible both that

- i Raj's hedonic level starts off fairly high, decreases suddenly, and then increases again a little later.
- ii Raj's well-being level starts off fairly high, decreases suddenly, and then increases again a little later.

They might then argue that the best *explanation* of this correlation between Raj's hedonic level and his level of well-being is that Raj's well-being is entirely determined by his hedonic level. Put another way, this correlation occurs because only his hedonic level affects his well-being level.

This argument is overly ambitious. The case of Raj gives us evidence that pleasure and pain contribute to well-being. But it does not show that *only* pleasure and pain contribute to well-being. The correlation between hedonic level and well-being level observed does not show that *other* things could not have also contributed to (or detracted from) Raj's well-being.

To see this, imagine a variation of the case where we keep Raj's hedonic level the same but add to Raj's life that he has extra friendships, or that he is successful in his major life goals, that he is more self-confident, or that he has more knowledge. It seems at least plausible that for some such cases Raj has a higher level of well-being than in the original, even though his hedonic level is the same in both cases.

There is a second weakness in the argument from correlation. It will be easier to see the problem with that argument by finding the same fault in a related argument for hedonism, the argument from paradigm cases. This is the claim that hedonism is supported by paradigm cases of people whose lives are going well. To put the argument formally, suppose the hedonist argues:

- 1 Paradigm cases of lives high in well-being all have high hedonic levels.
- 2 If the paradigm cases of lives high in well-being all have high hedonic levels then hedonism is true.

Therefore,

- 3 Hedonism is true.

This argument is valid. If the premises are true then the conclusion must be true. So, if there is a problem with the argument it must be that one or more of the premises is false.

One might have doubts about premise (1) but let us grant it for the sake of argument. The trouble comes from premise (2). The fact that paradigmatic cases of lives with high levels of well-being also have high hedonic levels is not *sufficient*

to show that hedonism is true. Paradigm cases of lives high in well-being may have *other*, non-hedonic, features that explain their high levels of well-being. So, whilst there might be a correlation between hedonic levels and high levels of well-being, it may be that a person's hedonic level does not *determine* their level of well-being. This is because we cannot always conclude from a correlation between two variables that one of them explains the other.

Here, first, is an example of how correlation between two variables does not allow us to safely conclude that one explains the other. My thermometer says '23 degrees' and it is 23 degrees. Later it says '21 degrees' and it is 21 degrees. There is thus a correlation between (i) the reading on my thermometer and (ii) the temperature. But we cannot conclude from this that the thermometer reading determines the temperature. That would be a mistake given that it's the temperature that determines the reading on the thermometer.

Sometimes we observe a correlation between two variables where we should conclude that *neither* explains the other. For example, consider the apparent correlation between the rate of drownings in outdoor swimming pools and ice cream sales.² Increases (and decreases) in drownings correlate with increases (and decreases) in ice cream sales. Should we conclude that drownings *determine* ice-cream sales (or vice versa)? Definitely not. *Why*, then, are these two things correlated? It is because a third variable – temperature – determines *both* the rate of drownings and ice cream sales. As temperatures go up, more people eat ice cream and more people use, and get into difficulties in, outdoor swimming pools. So, whilst there is a correlation between drownings and ice-cream sales neither explains the other. They are instead both explained by a third factor.

How can we use this idea of spurious (non-explanatory) correlations against the argument above? The answer is that we can use this observation to undermine premise (2) from the argument by pointing out that even if there is a correlation between hedonic level and well-being level (i.e. premise (1) is true) this *may* be explained by some third factor. (We will see an example of a candidate third factor in the next chapter, on desire-fulfilment theory.)

For now we can conclude the following. First, the case of Raj does not rule out things other than pleasure or pain from affecting well-being. Second, whilst the correlation between paradigmatic cases of lives high in well-being and lives with a high hedonic level provides *some* evidence for hedonism it does not by itself entitle us to conclude that hedonism is true. The correlation in question might be explained by some third variable.

It is worth pausing to briefly note that these are limitations of these specific *arguments* for hedonism. They are not, though, objections to hedonism or reasons to doubt the view (which we will turn to later).

Welfare subjects and pleasure and pain

Another kind of evidence that hedonists could appeal to in support of hedonism is the clear overlap between (i) things that have a level of well-being ('welfare

subjects') and (ii) things that experience pleasure and pain. Whilst it is implausible that pencils, telephones, and lampshades have levels of well-being, it is extremely plausible that gorillas, dolphins, and dogs are welfare subjects, that they have levels of well-being. Given that the former set of things cannot experience pleasure and pain but that the latter can, this is some evidence for hedonism.

One reply that non-hedonists will make is that the sets of things that do and do not plausibly have levels of well-being have *other* features that explain the division between them. For example, pencils, telephones, and lampshades are also incapable of desire, friendship, knowledge, and achievement, whereas gorillas, dolphins, and dogs plausibly are capable of at least a number of these things, if not all. Thus, it is not clear that this division (between things that are plausibly capable of well-being and things that are not) tracks *only* whether the relevant things can experience pleasure and pain. Nonetheless, because it is relatively plausible that the kinds of things that can have a level of well-being are also the kinds of things that can experience pleasure and pain, hedonism has a clear, plausible, answer to the question of why some things are welfare subjects and some are not. This is some evidence in favour of hedonism.

Motivational arguments

A third kind of argument that might be given for hedonism relies upon two claims about motivation. The first is that all action maximises self-interest (or at least aims to maximise self-interest). The second is that pleasure and pain are the *only* things capable of motivating us to act.

- 1 All human action aims to maximise well-being.
- 2 The agent's pleasure and pain are the only things capable of motivating them.

Therefore,

- 3 Hedonism is true.

Various responses are possible here. One is that (1) and (2) do not straightforwardly entail (3) so there is work to do to show that the argument is valid (that the conclusion must be true if the premises are true). But more importantly each of the first two premises of the argument is *highly* controversial.

It is *prima facie* implausible that agents always aim to maximise their own self-interest. Taking some everyday cases, we often seem to act against our own interests. We give money to charity (yes, even when no one is looking). We return property to people who have dropped it. To take more extreme examples, people often make great sacrifices to save others, knowing that it will certainly result in grave harm or death for themselves. Take soldiers who throw themselves on grenades to prevent harm to their fellow soldiers. To think that all such cases are

really cases where people are trying (but spectacularly failing) to maximise their self-interest seems highly implausible.

It is also *prima facie* implausible that agents are motivated only by the prospect of their own pleasure or avoidance of pain. Is it true that *nothing* else in the world motivates us to act? Take a case where you are walking along and see someone fall over. Aren't you sometimes motivated just by the thought that someone needs help? Don't people sometimes act from a sense of duty, or because they want to help a friend, or because they want to preserve something important for future generations?

Fully assessing these two premises here would take us too far afield. I simply note that this is one possible argument for hedonism. It is, I think, one that is implicit in some people's thought when thinking about hedonism. But it is an argument that requires *a lot* of support, given its contentious premises.

Experience requirement

A fourth reason that hedonists might give in support of their view is that hedonism nicely captures the idea that there is an *experience requirement* on well-being. This is the idea that what is good and bad for you must be experience-affecting (make a difference to your experience). To put this claim more precisely, a hedonist might argue that the following is true:

Experience requirement: If something contributes to someone's well-being it must affect their experience in some way.

They might then point out that pleasure and pain meet this experience requirement. This is because pleasure and pain necessarily affect experience. They might then conclude that the truth of the experience requirement, coupled with pleasure and pain satisfying the requirement, supports hedonism.

One way to resist this argument is to question the experience requirement itself. That is, we might question whether everything that affects a person's well-being must impact upon their experience. One kind of case that might be appealed to against the experience requirement is posthumous harms. If we can be harmed (or benefitted) by things after death then there is no experience requirement on well-being.

Yet even if we provisionally accept the experience requirement, we might question how strongly it supports hedonism. After all, pleasure and pain aren't the *only* things that make a difference to our experience. To give two examples, happiness and self-respect seem to be (a) distinct from pleasure and (b) things that affect our experience.³ And it is at least *prima facie* plausible that happiness and self-respect contribute to well-being. So, even if the hedonist is right that pleasure and pain affect our experience and that anything that affects well-being must affect an individual's experience it *still* does not follow that hedonism is true. There may be other, non-hedonic, goods that are compatible with the experience requirement.

Having examined some of the arguments for hedonism I now turn to objections to the view.

1.3 Objections to hedonism

The experience machine

In *Anarchy, State and Utopia*, Robert Nozick presents the following case in discussing hedonism:

Suppose there were an experience machine that would give you any experience you desired. Superduper neuropsychologists could stimulate your brain so that you would think and feel you were writing a great novel, or making a friend, or reading an interesting book. All the time you would be floating in a tank, with electrodes attached to your brain. Should you plug into this machine for life, pre-programming your life experiences?... You can pick and choose from their large library or smörgåsbord of such experiences, selecting your life's experiences for, say, the next two years. After two years have passed, you will have ten minutes or ten hours out of the tank, to select the experiences of your next two years. Of course, while in the tank you won't know that you're there; you'll think that it's all actually happening.⁴

Nozick's example is extremely engaging but features of the example introduce complications, some of which are potentially distracting. For that reason let me give a 'tidied up' version of the experience machine case before explaining what exactly it purports to show. (The case is similar to the variant cases of Raj above.)

Trudy and Flora: Trudy lives in New York. When not carrying on her ground-breaking research into stem cell treatment, she enjoys running marathons, working for a local charity, skiing, socialising with friends, and spending time with her life partner and their children. She also somehow finds time to pen highly successful, critically acclaimed novels. She enjoys great physical health and springs out of bed every morning full of joy and excitement.

Now meet Flora. When Flora was born she was attached to a machine that produces sensory stimulation and that gives her very rich, vivid, and life-like experiences. She has the pleasurable experience of carrying on ground-breaking research into stem cell treatment, of running marathons, of working for a local charity, skiing, socialising with friends, and spending time with her life partner and their children. She also has the experience of writing highly successful and critically acclaimed novels. She is kept physically healthy by the machine and she also has the experience of springing out of bed every morning full of joy and excitement.

Let us stipulate that Trudy and Flora have lives of identical length and that their hedonic levels are identical at every moment of these lives. What does hedonism

say about these two lives? Clearly, hedonism must conclude from the fact that Trudy and Flora have identical hedonic levels that they have identical levels of well-being. Furthermore, given the facts of their lives they both live lives that are equally *high* in well-being.

What should we conclude about hedonism from the case of Flora? Some will think that pleasurable experiences that are generated this way have little prudential value (perhaps, even, that they have prudential *disvalue*). Some will think that Flora lives an utterly wretched, awful life. These claims might be true. But they are much more controversial than the following claim, a claim that itself provides a strong reason to doubt hedonism. It is implausible that Trudy and Flora have *equal* levels of well-being. *Whatever* level of well-being one thinks is plausible for Trudy, it seems highly counterintuitive that Flora has that level of well-being also.

Some might think that Trudy and Flora *do* have equal levels of well-being. But suppose that one must choose which kind of life one's child would live (suppose that one's memory of making the choice would be immediately erased afterwards and one would have no possible contact with the child after making the choice). Shouldn't one choose the life of Trudy over the life of Flora? Plausibly so and this is because Trudy's life has a higher level of well-being.

Alternatively, consider a variant of the case where Flora's enjoys a *slightly* higher hedonic level over a short period. If hedonism is true then Flora has a higher level of well-being. But this seems implausible. Trudy's position seems much more desirable than Flora's. Her well-being seems higher.

Let us take stock. It is important not to overstate what experience machine-type cases might show. The case of Trudy and Flora does not show that pleasure does not contribute to well-being. Further, we need not think that the pleasure enjoyed by Flora has zero prudential value. But the case does provide a strong objection to the claim that well-being is determined *entirely* by a person's hedonic level. Plausibly, Trudy's level of well-being is higher than Flora's (despite equality in hedonic level) because she enjoys *real* friendships, *real* achievement, knowledge, etc. As Nozick puts the point:

[W]e want to *do* certain things, and not just have the experience of doing them...

[W]e want to *be* a certain way, to be a certain sort of person.⁵

In brief, the lesson of the experience machine is that hedonism provides at best an incomplete account of well-being. Pleasure does seem to contribute to well-being but other things contribute to well-being aside from pleasure.

Hedonist replies to the experience machine objection

How might a hedonist reply to the experience machine objection? There is no point in the hedonist objecting to the weirdness or outlandishness of the example. The example is clearly coherent and that is enough for it to be capable of being an objection to hedonism. After all, hedonism is not supposed to just be true of the

normal cases. It is supposed to be the truth about well-being in all cases. Similarly, there is no point in hedonists claiming that in fact the hedonic levels of Trudy and Flora would not be equal (on the basis, for example, that 'Flora would somehow know that her experiences were bogus'). The equality of hedonic level is *stipulated* as part of the example and the stipulation seems perfectly coherent. And we can imagine less unusual cases of people with equal hedonic levels but who differ with respect to achievement, friendship, etc. That is enough to put pressure on hedonism.

A better approach for the hedonist to use is to try to undermine our judgement that Trudy and Flora have unequal levels of well-being. There are several tactics they might employ. First, hedonists might point out that humans are prone to 'status quo bias', the mistake of giving undue weight to the option they believe to be the current state of affairs. Applied to this case the hedonist might argue that when thinking about the value of lives that are plugged into experience machines we are guilty of giving undue weight to the fact that we are not currently plugged into one.

A second way that hedonists can try to undermine the judgement that Trudy and Flora's lives have unequal levels of well-being is to point out that we do *not* seem to care, when thinking about the prudential disvalue of *pain*, whether it is based on a real experience or a charade. A painful experience plugged into the experience machine seems *just as bad* as a painful experience in reality, other things equal. The hedonist might then argue that, in the absence of a good reason to accept an asymmetry between pleasure and pain with respect to bogus experience, we should not think Trudy and Flora's lives have unequal levels of well-being.

One problem with this suggestion is that it does not tackle the thought that likely stands behind the judgement that Trudy and Flora's lives have unequal levels of well-being, namely that things *other than* pleasure and pain contribute to well-being. Someone might grant that all pleasure and pain is equally valuable whether or not it is based on real experiences yet *still* judge Trudy's level of well-being to be higher because of the non-hedonic differences between Trudy's life and Flora's.

A third way that the hedonist might try to dislodge the inequality judgement is by, first, pointing to the fact that people who are deceived tend to find out and experience pain and anguish and, then, arguing that when we think about Trudy and Flora's lives we are illegitimately assuming that Flora will find out about her deception and be very pained by it. This response is rather weak, and close to the first one suggested above. It relies upon the idea that when we think about the case of Trudy and Flora we are *simply unable* to stick to the stipulation that their hedonic levels are identical. But, in the absence of evidence of such an inability, the response is not powerful.⁶

Finally, some hedonists have taken to wielding evolutionary debunking arguments against the experience machine. To understand these arguments we need to know what a debunking argument is in general. A debunking argument aims to show that the *source* of some belief makes that belief illegitimate in some way (that it is false, that it is unjustified, or merely that it has less support or justification than previously suspected). Everyday examples of debunking arguments appear when people claim that some person holds some belief only because of their upbringing,

or because it suits their interests, or because they have been indoctrinated. A general form of debunking argument is:

- 1 Your belief that J stems from process P.
- 2 Beliefs that stem from process P are illegitimate.

Therefore,

- 3 Your belief that J is illegitimate.

An evolutionary debunking argument in particular is one that claims that evolution is the problematic process P. The evolutionary debunking arguments given by hedonists against the experience machine objection suppose that our anti-hedonistic responses to the experience machine case are a by-product of evolution. Put briefly, the suggestion is that in our evolutionary history it was advantageous to *believe* that, for example, friendship and achievement are good for us. Why so? Because having such beliefs tends to make us pursue friendship and achievement and this, in turn, improves our chances of survival and propagation. Thus, creatures with these beliefs, or disposed to form them, were more likely to pass on their genetic material.

The crucial point that the hedonist will then press is that this story of *why* it was evolutionarily advantageous for us to believe these things (e.g. that friendship and achievement have prudential value) did not require that the beliefs be true. Even if hedonism is true it could still be very useful for creatures to (falsely) believe that friendship and achievement are prudentially valuable. Why? Because such creatures would more likely survive and pass on their genes for the reasons given above. There is no reason to think that the evolutionary processes that generated these evolutionarily advantageous beliefs were truth-tracking. So, we should be suspicious of these beliefs.

Put very schematically, the argument would be this:

- 1 Your belief that things other than pleasure and pain affect well-being stems from non-truth-tracking, evolutionary, processes.
- 2 Beliefs that stem from non-truth-tracking processes are illegitimate.

Therefore,

- 3 Your belief that things other than pleasure and pain affect well-being is illegitimate.

There are many details one could explore here. The most important point is that this argument is a problematic weapon for the *hedonist* to deploy. To the extent that it is a good objection to the non-hedonist it is an even better objection to hedonism itself.⁷ Why so?

Think of the overlap between pleasurable behaviours and evolutionarily advantageous behaviours. It is easy to think of behaviours that are both pleasurable and that were evolutionarily advantageous for humans to engage in (having sex, eating, recreation) and, conversely, behaviours that are both painful and that were evolutionarily disadvantageous for humans to engage in (damaging one's own body, starving oneself, attacking large predators). Given this fact, it seems that a plausible evolutionary debunking story can be told of why it was advantageous for humans to believe that *pleasure is good for them* and that this story (also) does not require that the belief was true. After all, creatures that had the belief (*pleasure is good for me*) were more likely to have sex, eat, engage in recreation and they thereby increased their chances of reproductive success.

The upshot of this is that *if* we should doubt, on evolutionary grounds, our non-hedonic judgements about well-being, we should also doubt our judgements that pleasure and pain are good and bad for us. To put it bluntly, *if* speculation about the evolutionary causes of our beliefs gives us reason to doubt that friendship and achievement are good for us, then we have just as much reason to be suspicious that pleasure is good for us, absent some relevant difference between the cases.

Base pleasures

Whilst the experience machine objection targeted the hedonists' claim that *only* pleasures contribute positively to well-being, the 'base pleasures objection' targets the claim that *all* pleasures contribute to well-being.

Some examples of the kinds of pleasures that feature in the base pleasures objection are:

- immoral pleasures (e.g. pleasures connected to immoral actions – enjoyment of torture, or of watching torture)
- pleasures from trivial or low-brow sources (e.g. pleasures from watching reality TV)
- pleasures that are undignified (e.g. pleasure from wallowing in mud like a pig).⁸

As this list makes clear, quite a diverse array of pleasures might be mentioned by someone wielding the base pleasures objection. The basic form of the objection is as follows:

Base pleasures objection

- 1 If hedonism is true then all pleasures contribute to well-being.
- 2 If all pleasures contribute to well-being then *base* pleasures contribute to well-being.
- 3 Base pleasures do not contribute to well-being.

Therefore,

4 Hedonism is false.

(There is also a second version of the base pleasures objection, which I will discuss below.)

Replies to the base pleasures objection

With one exception, the standard hedonistic replies to the base pleasures objection involve accepting premise (2) but denying premise (3). What the hedonist does is to argue that premise (3) is false, and so the argument is unsound. The different ways of rejecting (3) revolve around the claim that when we think about cases of base pleasures, and form the judgement that they do not contribute to well-being, we are making some sort of mistake. What mistake might we be making?

1 Instrumental disvalue distractions

One of the objections hedonists can make to the base pleasures objection is that our belief that base pleasures are not prudentially valuable is a mistaken judgement based on the expectation that such pleasures would lead to future harms. For example, perhaps when we consider the case of the torturer we are illegitimately thinking about the consequences of having a sadistic character, of having few or no significant friendships or personal relationships, or the likely punishment or retribution such a person might face. We thus undervalue how prudentially good the pleasure is.

This objection has some merit. A sadistic character generally does have bad consequences for a person. But that fact is unlikely to dislodge the judgement that, for example, pleasure from torture just is, itself, of no prudential value to the person who experiences it. Those who form that judgement are likely to hold that it is still true even if we are very careful to stipulate away all these possible distractions.

2 Wrong kind of value judgement

A second, perhaps more persuasive, suggestion that the hedonist can make as to why we mistakenly believe premise (3) is that we are conflating two kinds of value. In thinking about these cases we are being distracted by the *moral* disvalue of such pleasures and mistaking this for a lack of *prudential* value. Put another way, the hedonist might claim that we are being distracted by the moral badness of such pleasures and mistakenly thinking that the pleasures lack prudential value. The hedonist might then maintain that if we keep in mind that we are considering *only* the prudential value of such pleasures then we will see that they really are prudentially valuable.

To make this a little less abstract, the hedonist might urge us to think more precisely about the case. They might claim that it is tempting to contrast the case of the person who takes pleasure in torture with the person who enjoys some perfectly

innocent pursuit (e.g. playing music). But, so the hedonist might claim, if we make that comparison then the difference in the *moral* value of these pleasures might lead us to illegitimately ascribe a difference in their *prudential* value. They might then claim that what we should do instead is to compare the case of someone deriving pleasure from inflicting torture with the case of the person who tortures but without enjoying it, or who tortures and is pained by doing so:

Case of the three torturers

	<i>Hedonic level</i>
Torturer 1	+10
Torturer 2	0
Torturer 3	–10

When we think of the case of the three torturers, is it plausible that the pleasure is good for the agent? One way to think about the question is to ask which torturer is *worst off* (other things equal). Is it torturer 1, engaging in torture but enjoying it? Or would one be better off in torturer 2's situation, or even torturer 3's?

Focusing on the comparative question might help us to make some progress. I think at least some people who were inclined to doubt the prudential value of malicious pleasures in the original case will think that torturer 1 is best off and that this is fairly good evidence that torturer 1's pleasure is in fact prudentially valuable. Thus, the focus on the comparative question will shift some people from holding premise (3). The trouble though is that for many people the comparative question will actually *enhance* their commitment to the correctness of premise (3). That is, those whose commitment to (3) was clear-minded – not based on some mistake such as a mistake in the kind of evaluation made – will likely hold that to take pleasure in something so depraved as torture is *bad for you*. One can imagine them replying that one should want to be torturer 2, perhaps even torturer 3, if faced with the grim dilemma of having to be in one of these three positions.

3 *Qualitative hedonism*

I mentioned above that there are two different arguments from base pleasures against hedonism. The argument from base pleasures given above worked by highlighting some problematic pleasures and arguing that such pleasures hold no prudential value and so hedonism is false. A different kind of base pleasures objection focuses more directly on the fact that hedonism ascribes equal prudential value to different pleasures. This variant argument runs as follows:

Base pleasures equality objection

- 1 If hedonism is true then all *equal-sized* pleasures contribute equally to well-being.

- 2 If all equal-sized pleasures contribute equally to well-being then base pleasures of a given size contribute to well-being as much as non-base pleasures of the same size.
- 3 Base pleasures of a given size do not contribute to well-being equally with non-base pleasures of the same size.

Therefore,

- 4 Hedonism is false.

The difference between this argument and the previous one might be difficult to see. To get a clearer idea, take the following pair of cases:

	<i>Hedonic level</i>
S wallows in mud like a pig for 3 hours	+10
S reads <i>Hamlet</i>	+10

Someone might object to hedonism not because it ascribes prudential value to each pleasure but, instead, because it says S would be *equally* well off wallowing in mud like a pig as reading *Hamlet*. Put another way, hedonism claims that the pleasures from wallowing in mud like a pig are just as valuable as the pleasures from reading *Hamlet*. The objector then claims that this result is implausible and that S would be better off reading *Hamlet*.

To see the difference between this objection and the previous one, notice that the objector need not claim that the pleasure derived from wallowing in mud like a pig has no value. They need only claim that this pleasure is not *equally* good for the agent as the pleasure from the more lofty pursuit.

The difference between these two base pleasure objections is not always clearly drawn but it is worth being clear given the *different* kinds of responses that hedonists might wish to make to the different objections.

What can a hedonist say in response to the *base pleasures equality objection*? Of course they can make some of the same responses featured. They can claim that the wielder of this objection is confusing the question of what is good for the agent with (e.g.) what it would be best to do overall. And perhaps someone who reads literature is more likely to generate well-being for others than someone who derives pleasure from wallowing in mud like a pig. Alternatively, the hedonist can claim that the likely consequences of reading literature are more positive *for the agent* than the likely results of wallowing in mud like a pig. That is to say, there might be more *instrumental* value to the pleasure of reading literature than the pleasure of wallowing like a pig. Why might this be so? Perhaps pleasures derived from literature are more easily recreated, or better enable us to derive further pleasures than the purely sensory ones. The hedonist might then claim that when we judge the sensory pleasure to be inferior we are mistaking the greater *instrumental* value that is typical of pleasure derived from reading literature for a difference in non-instrumental value.

A more philosophically interesting move available to the hedonist is to, first, concede that the pleasure from wallowing in mud like a pig is less prudentially valuable (non-instrumentally) than the pleasure from reading *Hamlet* and, second, claim that this is no problem for hedonism because hedonism is consistent with rejecting the claim that equal-sized pleasures always have equal value. Looking back at the base pleasures equality objection, such a hedonist is rejecting premise (1) of that argument:

- 1 If hedonism is true then all equal-sized pleasures contribute equally to well-being.

The idea of a qualitative form of hedonism which rejects (1) is famously associated with John Stuart Mill. As Mill puts the idea:

It would be absurd to think that while, in estimating all other things, quality is considered as well as quantity, the estimation of pleasures should be supposed to depend on quantity alone.⁹

Mill held that pleasures had different levels of quality and that the value of a pleasure was determined not only by its quantity but also by its *quality*.

To return to the case above, a qualitative hedonist might claim that they can accommodate the judgement that the pleasure from reading *Hamlet* has more prudential value than the pleasure from wallowing in mud like a pig. The reason they will give is that the pleasure from reading *Hamlet* is of higher *quality*.

Mill's qualitative hedonism received a barrage of criticism.¹⁰ A common objection is that it is inconsistent for a hedonist to think that pleasures can have different levels of quality. Why so? The thought behind the objection is as follows: if such *pleasures* have different values then this can *only* be because of the different levels of value in the respective *activities* that generate the pleasures. But if only pleasure has value then there are no differences in value in the activities that produce pleasure (because activities that produce pleasure are not, themselves, prudentially valuable).

One problem with this objection is that it presumes that qualitative hedonism can only treat differences in the quality of pleasure as differences in the activities that produce pleasure. But that is only one way to interpret the idea of pleasures being of different quality. Why not think that the pleasures themselves have different qualities?

Part of what is at issue here is something that we left aside at the beginning of the chapter: the *nature* of pleasure. One view is that pleasures are intrinsically homogeneous mental states, differing only with respect to intensity and duration. If one assumes that view of pleasure, then it makes sense to think that differences in quality of pleasure can only be differences in the value of the activities that produce them. With these background assumptions in place, qualitative hedonism can seem unmotivated and implausible. *Why* does it affect the prudential value of pleasure that it stems from one activity rather than another if the pleasures themselves are intrinsically homogeneous?

An alternative view – perhaps the most intuitive way of understanding qualitative hedonism – is that pleasures are themselves *heterogeneous*. That is, pleasures have different intrinsic natures. If so, the pleasure derived from reading *Hamlet* might be intrinsically different from that derived from wallowing in mud like a pig. If this is the correct view of pleasure then it seems like an open possibility that the different intrinsic natures of pleasure are, or produce, differences in the quality of those pleasures. Thus, one could be a qualitative hedonist, and try to avoid the base pleasures equality objection, by claiming that pleasures have differing intrinsic natures.

1.4 Conclusion

In this chapter we have considered hedonism about prudential value. The hedonist view is that all and only pleasure is good for you and that all and only pain is bad for you. We then looked at some arguments for the view and some objections. The objections targeted different features of hedonism. One of them – the experience machine – targeted hedonism’s claim that, necessarily, everyone at the same hedonic level has the same level of well-being. Others targeted the way that hedonism gives value, or equal value, to problematic kinds of pleasures.

It is worth noticing that none of these objections claimed that *no* pleasures or pain have prudential value and disvalue. That is, none of the objections above even purported to show that pleasures (pain) are never good (bad) for us. They only targeted the stronger claims definitive of hedonism, namely that all and only pleasures (pain) are good (bad) for us. In light of this we might conclude that pleasure and pain are at least sometimes prudentially valuable even if hedonism is mistaken that they are the only things that determine well-being.

Comprehension questions

- 1 If hedonism is true, is money good for us in precisely the same way that pleasure is?
- 2 What would make it true that it is in a person’s best interests not to smoke, if hedonism is true?
- 3 What, if anything, is problematic about Nozick’s original experience machine example?
- 4 What is qualitative hedonism about prudential value? How does it differ from purely quantitative hedonism?

Further questions

- 1 Philosophers sometimes object to hedonism on the grounds that pleasures are heterogeneous. Is this a good objection?
- 2 What, if anything, do different pleasures have in common? What unites the pleasure of reading a great novel with the pleasure of going on a waterslide?

Notes

- 1 On this, see Bramble (2013, 2016a), Feldman (2004), Gosling (1969), Gregory (2016), Heathwood (2013), etc.
- 2 Example from: <http://blogs.seattletimes.com/educationlab/2013/12/04/ice-cream-doesnt-cause-drowning-and-other-warnings-about-interpreting-data>, accessed 22 December 2015.
- 3 See, for example, Haybron (2008: Chapter 4).
- 4 Nozick (1974: 42–45).
- 5 Nozick (1974: 43).
- 6 One might also think that the reason we would be upset to discover that our lives are like this is because their being so would be bad for us. the hedonist must deny this. For more discussion see Nagel (1970).
- 7 For more on this, see Fletcher (2007).
- 8 Example from Feldman (2004).
- 9 Mill (1863: Chapter 2).
- 10 See, for example, Moore (2000 [1903]). For extensive discussion of these issues, see, for example, Feldman (2004).

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